

Google has been in the automobile industry for a while now. The internet giant has dabbled with cars for almost a decade, but not until the recent years have its efforts been truly noticed, talked about and even had a major impact on the rest of the industry. In fact, Google is now addressed as one of the very first movers in a segment that is expected to lead automobile innovation in the coming years, and that is owing to this one particular crazy experiment.

The Google Self-Driving Car Project

Quite aptly referred to as 'Project Chauffeur', the Google Self-Driving Car Project begun way back in 2009, with only one goal in sight – building a completely autonomous car by 2020. The idea was to build one prototype that would be able to successfully drive itself across real-life scenarios, and then replicate the technology en masse.

How it all began

Google chose Stanford University professor Sebastian Thrun to head this project. Interestingly, Thrun was working on making cars drive themselves for a while, and had won the \$2 million grand prize of the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) Grand Challenge in 2005. He led a team of Stanford students and faculty to build Stanley – a 'robot car' based on a 2004 Volkswagen Touareg R5 TDI, fitted with an Intel-powered six-processor computing platform, and a host of actuators and sensors. Aiding the Stanley robot car across nearly 230 kilometres through the Mojave desert were experts from The Volkswagen of America, Intel Research and others.

It is this expertise, along with the basic formula of using peripheral imagery and feeding it to onboard computers to make a car drive itself, that Thrun brought to Google. In 2009, the Google Self-Driving Car Project began with other notable engineers like Chris Urmson (who won the same DARPA Challenge in 2007) and Anthony Levandowski, who has more recently been the centre of the Uber v. Google controversy.

Alongside Thrun, Levandowski has been one of the key first innovators in the autonomous vehicle space. He founded two companies that were later acquired by Google – 510 Systems and Anthony's Robots. While the former worked on Lidar modules, which as we know now are crucial for self-driving cars, the latter was focused on getting an actual self-maneuvering car on public roads. Levandowski used a Toyota Prius, calling it 'Pribot', and fitted